Akbar's court from about 1560 onwards (the year, perhaps coincidentally, of Bairam's fall). The first were 'Indian Muslims', including 'Shaikhzadas', descendants of earlier Muslim immigrants to Hindustan, or of converts.[45] The second, of course, were Rajputs.

In 1564, a year after he married Harkha Bai and some three years before the siege of Chittorgarh, Akbar had abolished the *jizya*. Translated rather inscrutably as 'poll tax', the jizya becomes more controversial, indeed incendiary, the further it recedes into the past. Simply put, it was a tax collected by Muslim rulers from their non-Muslim subjects that has been variously understood and interpreted – from wilful humiliation of non-believers, on the one hand, to a more dispassionate method by which non-Muslim subjects would have to pay the equivalent of zakat, the annual charity that is part of the Islamic faith.

Banning the jizya would have pleased Akbar's new Rajput commanders, and that is quite likely why he did it. Now, it seems, Akbar was making 'efforts at placating orthodox Muslim sentiments'.[46] Thus, Iqtidar Alam Khan continues, the padishah 'adopted a vigorous policy to reduce [Rajputs] into submission by force' – such as the gratuitous bloodshed at Chittorgarh. As if to prove Khan's point, Akbar issued an aggressive *fathnama*, a proclamation of victory, afterwards, 'full of intolerant professions and sentiments', declaring the 'fall of Chittor . . . as the victory of Islam over infidels'.[47]

Abul Fazl, writing many long years after the fall of the fortress, when any such policy of performative aggression against Rajput – or non-Muslim – subjects had fallen by the wayside, does not breathe a word of this fathnama. Instead, he removes the sting of sectarian slaughter from the tale by turning Chittorgarh's civilian population into a battle force. Thus, Akbar's historian writes of how, when Alauddin Khilji took the fort, he had left its inhabitants unharmed, but only because they had 'not engaged in fighting'. This time, the citizens had fought Akbar; their subsequent 'excuses . . . were of no avail', so they were killed.

~

The butchery went on from dawn to noon. Only Chittor's musketeers escaped it: pretending to be Mughal soldiers, tying up their families and